

Lesson 11: Negotiation for Women

Nikki Caldwell Fargas

Who's ready for a fun one – *negotiation*! Who *doesn't* want to be a better negotiator...am I right?

The truth is, negotiating can be intimidating for a lot of reasons. You're communicating with someone – usually in a power position of some sort – trying to come to a mutual agreement. They have power over an outcome you want...or vice versa.

You may be negotiating something you care deeply about, like your salary, a new job role, or the hire of a new team member, and it's hard to keep emotions out of the way.

Negotiating may be challenging, but that's part of the fun of it. You can rise to this challenge! And the results are usually worth the effort. Nothing ventured, nothing gained.

And negotiation doesn't always have to be in a board room. The truth is, we negotiate every day in ways we don't even realize.

There was this one time I was an assistant coach for Pat Summitt. We had a player that was late for curfew and Pat runs a very disciplined program. So if you miss curfew, that meant an automatic suspension for the next game. Well, this player in her entire career had never missed anything. And so Pat was very disappointed as we all were, and she was going to suspend the player for the next game.

Now, mind you, we scheduled this game because we enjoyed taking players back to their hometown or near where they grew up, and we would play the closest university. So when Pat was alerted that this player had missed curfew, I was torn, because I knew that this person had made a mistake. So at that time, I felt the need to step in and negotiate on behalf of the player with Coach Summitt.

So, through the negotiation, we were able to arrive at a mutual agreement. The negotiation ended with the player only missing half of the game. I felt that was a win for both sides. So, in negotiation, it is important to come to a mutually agreed upon decision that serves both sides. And I'm so glad we went on to win the game.

Pat herself negotiated her salary from a little less than \$9,000 when she first started out, to more than \$1 million by the time she finished her career. And she would be the first to tell you she grew up as a farm-girl from Henrietta, Tennessee!

This lesson will cover some basics and help make sure you know a few tips you can practice to take your negotiating tips to the next level, wherever you are today.

First, you want to make sure you approach any negotiation with the right attitude. Remember, you are trying to come to a mutual agreement that meets your needs, but without alienating the other party – especially in the business world. You don't want to take the approach of "my way or the highway," but you don't want to cave in either. Don't view it as something to be "won" or "lost. That can be intimidating in itself. You're there to participate in the negotiation and go as far as you can towards an outcome everyone is happy with.

Use silences to your advantage in a negotiation. Give the other time to process and think.

Listen for their "no," or any objections...those aren't blockers or dealbreakers. Those are only the starting point in a real negotiation. If they *don't* give you their objections, you can't find a way around those objections and it's hard to continue the conversation.

You want to clarify what you're hearing at each step of the negotiating so you can isolate exactly what any objection points may be.

"So, it sounds like you're saying you'd be willing to change the venue if we could come down on price, is that right?"

"So, you're saying you would be open to giving me a salary increase around the first of year if I'm able to demonstrate the value I've added to the team by Q4, is that correct?"

Finally, *don't* expect the other side to be won over purely by your logic. If logic was the sole determining factor in a negotiation, we probably wouldn't be having a negotiation. There are usually variables or details people are emotionally invested in. Sometimes it comes down to pure old-fashioned pride and not wanting look weak or that you "lost" an argument.

There are also special points to consider when negotiating your salary. We'll go over all this and more in the upcoming lesson.